PREFACE

In writing this Grammar we have kept steadily in view the class of students for whom the Series of Grammars was originally planned. As it is not intended for specialists, some details of more or less importance have been intentionally omitted, but we venture to think that the present volume contains all that the ordinary student will require to know about the subject. The student who thoroughly masters the book will not only have gained a comprehensive knowledge of Old English, but will also have acquired the elements of Comparative Germanic grammar. But from our long experience as teachers of the subject, we should strongly recommend the beginner not to work through the phonology at the outset, but to read Chapter I and sections 47–53, and then to learn the paradigms, and at the same time to read some easy texts such as are to be found in any of the Old English Readers. This is undoubtedly the best plan in the end, and will lead to the most satisfactory results. In fact, it is in our opinion a sheer waste of time for a student to attempt to study in detail the phonology of any language before he has acquired a good working knowledge of its vocabulary and inflexions.

In selecting examples to illustrate the sound-laws we have tried as far as possible to give words which have been preserved in Modern English. A comparison of the Index to the Grammar with an Old English Dictionary would show that we have thus included nearly all the simple words which have been preserved in the modern language. Our object in doing this was to enable the

student to lay a solid foundation for his further study of historical English grammar, and to provide a basis for the next volume of the Series, which will deal with Middle English.

It was originally our intention to include in the present volume some chapters on Syntax, but it was found that the inclusion of these chapters would have rendered the book too large for the Series. This omission of the syntax cannot however be regarded as a serious drawback, because the volume dealing with historical English syntax is already in active preparation, and will, it is hoped, be ready for press this year.

Although this Grammar makes no pretence of being an exhaustive work, yet it is by far the most complete Grammar that has hitherto been written in our own language, and the first to deal with the subject in a strictly scientific manner. We gratefully acknowledge the help we have derived from the learned articles and books by that splendid band of German Anglisten which has done so much to throw light upon the history and philology of our language in all its stages. On pp. xiii–xiv will be found a select list of the books which we have found most useful, but it is our pleasant duty to mention here our special indebtedness to the works of Bülbring, Cosijn, and Sievers.

In conclusion, we wish to express our sincere thanks to the Controller of the University Press for his great kindness in complying with our wishes in regard to special type, and to the Press Reader for the excellent manner in which he has read the proofs.

JOSEPH WRIGHT.
ELIZABETH M. WRIGHT.

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ABBREVIATIONS

Dor.	= Doric	MHG.	= Middle High German
Fr.	= French	NE.	= New English
Germ.	= Germanic	NHG.	= New High German
Goth.	= Gothic	Nth	= Northumbrian
Gr.	= Greek	OE.	= Old English
Hom.	= Homer	OHG.	= Old High German
Indg.	= Indo-Germanic	O.Icel.	= Old Icelandic
instr.	= instrumental	O.Ir.	= Old Irish
Ken.	= Kentish	OS.	= Old Saxon
Lat.	= Latin	Prim.	= Primitive
loc.	= locative	Skr.	= Sanskrit
ME.	= Middle English	WS.	= West Saxon

The asterisk * prefixed to a word denotes a theoretical form, as OE. **dæg**, *day*, from Prim. Germanic ***đaȝaz**.